

Smart Farmers of the Past

Non-fiction

By 2030, it is estimated that over 8.5 billion people will live on our planet. Every single one of them will need access to nutritious food to stay healthy. Feeding this enormous population is one of the greatest challenges facing humanity — and it is one that farmers have always had to face.

Many people think farmers from the past were simply country folk who planted seeds and hoped for the best. In fact, they were some of the most skilled inventors in human history, creating extraordinary solutions to grow food in difficult conditions.

Terraces

Farming on high ground is difficult. When it rains or snows, the soil gets swept down the slopes and farmland on flat ground is far easier to manage. However, hill-dwellers developed a brilliant technique called terracing to solve this problem. By cutting flat sections into the hillside, they transformed steep slopes into a series of steps on which crops could be grown. Good examples of terraced farming can be found all over the world. In southeast Asia, paddy fields are built on terraces to grow rice. In southern Europe and South America — especially Peru — terraces were used to grow a wide variety of crops. It was in South America that potatoes were first grown on terraces, long before they were introduced to Europe. Terraces are also used to grow crops such as olives and grapes in hilly parts of Europe. The flat sections prevent the soil from washing away and make it easier to water the plants. The amount of vital farmland this created was remarkable.

Irrigation

Plants need water to grow, but it doesn't always fall where it is needed. Irrigation is the method of bringing water from elsewhere so that farmers can make sure that plants are able to grow even in dry conditions. It is one of the greatest farming achievements of all time. In ancient Egypt, farmers waited for the River Nile to flood each year. When the waters retreated, they left behind a layer of rich, fertile soil. Egyptian farmers used channels to direct this water to their crops as it receded. Nearly three thousand years ago, farmers in Persia (now Iran) developed a system called qanats — underground tunnels that carried water from mountain springs to dry lowland fields. This allowed communities to thrive in areas that would otherwise have been too arid to farm. The farmers of the past had very little equipment compared to us, yet they fed millions of people and invented techniques that are still used today. Their ingenuity and hard work deserve our admiration and respect.